# While It Lasts - Labyrinth Documentation

**Title**
While It Lasts

**One-line teaser**
In death, rebirth awaits.

**Three-line summary of your concept**
In “While It Lasts,” you become an explorer who follows the last survivor of an unknown species through a cave system on the planet Kharos-9. You earn the creature's trust, feed it, and accompany it into death and beyond. Will you enjoy it while it lasts?

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3-4 meaningful pictures (photo montages, sketches, etc.)

**Links**
- Teaser: Labyrinth 1 Teaser.mp4 https://youtu.be/OrEaBnIldkQ
- Video documentation of the experience: https://youtu.be/IscYvCT8pIc

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# Introduction

## Task & Briefing

The task is to create a music festival experience that will make participants feel truly alive. The Alive Festival will provide the climax for the media department's summer festival after the Absolvia and Mediale on Friday, 24th of July. It features three different formats: the Main Stage, the Labyrinth, and an XR Experience. The final delivery includes the festival itself, a teaser for social media, an experience trailer and this project documentation. At the beginning of the semester, we decided to use the labyrinth format because we saw it as an exciting challenge that offered a lot of creative freedom. This documentation follows our entire process, from the very first idea until the final result. Enjoy this journey… while it lasts.

## The Queens

Pictures of Us, maybe a short description who did what, like how we worked together and so on

From Russia to Mexico, from Namibia to Germany and Thailand, we are a team shaped by different cultures, backgrounds, and talents. Diverse in where we come from, united in what we create together.

# Research

The research phase this semester was a bit more unconventional and intuitive than usual. We spent a lot of time exploring what makes us feel alive, how those emotions are activated, and what it actually means to be alive. Through short writing sessions and personal reflections, we found moments and memories where we felt truly alive. These exercises helped us be more in tune with our emotional landscape and the core of our project.

As a starting point, we collected images, music videos, film scenes and other media that evoked this sense of aliveness. Although the references chosen by each of us varied in atmosphere, genre, and aesthetics, we found some recurring themes. The different media pieces shared an emphasis on sensory experience and strong emotions.

Throughout our discussions, we became interested in the relationship between emotions and embodiment. To feel alive requires a body capable of perceiving and processing the countless stimuli that surround us. Smells, sounds, textures and interactions all pass through the body and transform into emotions. It is this capacity to feel, to be affected, and to respond that constitutes the sense of being alive. Experiences of excitement, intimacy, risk, exhaustion, sadness, or longing all appeared equally capable of producing a strong awareness of being alive. The feeling itself seemed less connected to happiness and more to presence. To moments in which we are fully immersed, emotionally vulnerable, or just aware of our own bodies and surroundings.

The following references inspired us throughout the development of the project:

(list of examples from our first presentation, maybe just one page with pictures and 2-4 links for music)

# Define

## Target Audience

Our Experience is designed for students and professors, as well as friends and families, who visit the alive festival and look for a shared emotional experience. It also appeals to anyone interested in electronic music, installation art, immersive environments and projection technology.

# Ideation

## HMW Question

Before the actual ideation process, we individually defined HMW questions and chose the most important together. The questions come from our research, the project brief, and the define phase.

1. How might we create an immersive experience that reconnects people with themselves?

2. How might we transform a labyrinth into an emotional and narrative journey?
3. How might we use multisensory storytelling to make visitors feel present, alive, and emotionally engaged?
4. How might we encourage visitors to actively participate rather than passively observe?
5. How might we create a clear emotional arc and memorable climax?
6. How might we create a visually and emotionally powerful experience with minimal budget and technical resources?

## Braindump

After defining our HMW (How Might We) questions, we started the braindump phase. To provide some structure, we organized our ideas into four categories: Characters, Story World, Location, and General Ideas. We then brainstormed individually in short sprints. At this stage, the goal was not to judge or refine ideas, but simply to capture as many possibilities as possible and share them with one another.

**Characters**

Our character ideas ranged from concrete figures to abstract beings. One imagined the visitors trapped in a horror movie inspired by Dead by Daylight, endlessly attempting to escape a mansion they can never truly leave. Other ideas explored life itself as an entity: a plant or organism that is born at the beginning of the experience and dies at the end, emphasizing the temporary nature of existence.

Several ideas focused on abstract forms. One vision portrayed life as a gender-fluid being without a fixed shape, with galaxies for eyes and hair made of stardust. Another introduced the Wanderer, an eternal presence that has always existed in this space, alongside the Overseer, a guide who instinctively knows the path through crystalline structures. Other character ideas included an organism living inside a much larger organism, a nun, a transparent creature whose veins and body react to sound and music, and even a red blood cell travelling through the human body.

**Story World**

Our story world ideas explored themes of mortality, transformation, and perspective. One narrative imagined visitors entering an abandoned mansion, only to discover that it is haunted and impossible to escape. Death is inevitable, but the focus lies on how one dies and what emotions are experienced beforehand.

Other ideas revolved around being inside a living organism, perhaps as the last surviving member of a species, trying to preserve life or experience existence through another being. Some concepts focused on the final moments before the end of the world, where visitors relive emotions one last time before the world ends and they turn into stardust.

Alternative perspectives included experiencing life through the eyes of an alien observing Earth, uncovering traces and echoes of the past, or wandering through a realm hidden between rays of sunlight inhabited by mythical creatures. Another story world imagined neurons searching through darkness to connect and create the spark of knowledge, reflecting the circle of life and the evolution of living organisms.

**Location**

The locations varied between realistic and highly abstract environments. One idea centered around an abandoned mansion with a dark history, transforming the labyrinth into a haunted attraction with live music and unsettling mascots such as a creepy clown. Other settings included a fantasy world where tiny humans live inside giant creatures, outer space, and the interior of the human body. More playful locations, such as a disco, contrasted with abstract spaces inspired by bodily processes, crystalline reflections, and the chaotic electrical pathways between synapses.

**General Ideas**

Many of our ideas focused on creating emotional and sensory experiences. One idea imagined the labyrinth as a haunted circus that visitors attempt to escape, although escape is impossible. Another idea was that the labyrinth was a space that helps visitors reflect on the meaning of life, with the environment acting as a projection of their emotions. The space could serve as a retreat from the intensity of the main stage, featuring floating lights resembling fireflies and a dreamlike atmosphere. Additional ideas included a circus composed of different but interconnected acts, a journey through the human body and its reactions, and the story of a nun who discovers her passion for music and dance.

One particularly interesting direction imagined the entire space behaving like a living organism, where sound and vibration form its nervous system. Music becomes its breath, expanding and contracting the environment, while every sonic change triggers a corresponding visual response, creating a constantly evolving and living experience.

## Our first Concept Draft

Based on our braindump, each of us was assigned the task of developing an initial concept. We already had a few common elements that were important to all of us, but we left it open as to whether or not these would be incorporated into the concept draft. The main goal was to get creative again and let our imaginations run wild. After presenting our individual concepts to one another, we identified the aspects that held the most potential for an immersive labyrinth experience and that we liked the best. We evaluated these aspects, refined them, and ultimately developed them into an initial joint concept draft.

The resulting concept, *While It Lasts*, envisions an immersive labyrinth centered around an abstract living organism that serves as a metaphor for life, emotions, and shared existence. The experience follows the organism through a full life cycle, beginning with birth, passing through different emotional states, and culminating in death, and rebirth. The focus is not on death and its finality, but on the rebirth and the opportunity for renewal. As visitors move through the labyrinth, they become part of the organism itself. Their presence influences its behavior, while the evolving environment reflects the fleeting, unstable, and constantly changing nature of emotions and life. Emotional states are communicated through sensory experiences, including temperature, sound, scent, lighting, and tactile interaction, emphasizing the role of the body in perceiving and experiencing life.

The visual language is fluid and ambiguous. The organism has no fixed identity, continuously transforming between biological, neural, floral, and alien-like forms. At times it appears tangible and familiar, while at others it becomes abstract and unrecognizable. Organic patterns such as veins, flowing structures, translucent materials, dynamic lighting, and natural color palettes reinforce the impression of a living system that breathes, reacts, and evolves in synchronization with sound and music. Interactive elements, including motion tracking and responsive objects, further strengthen the connection between visitors and the environment by allowing the organism to react to movement and presence.

The concept is aimed at audiences interested in electronic and indie music, immersive installations, and interactive art, particularly students, academics, festival visitors, and individuals from creative communities. Through the combination of multisensory stimuli and interactive storytelling, *While It Lasts* seeks to encourage reflection on what it means to be alive, highlighting the importance of presence, emotional experience, and the transient nature of life itself.

# Developing the Concept

## Overview

After a few rounds of iterations and coaching sessions with Georg, Claudius, Owi, Mr. Allinger, and Matthias (thanks for the support), the almost final concept was born (or rather: Ori was born... and then died... and then came back to life).

We started with an idea and a visual language inspired by the world of H. R. Giger. However, as the concept developed, we realised that this aesthetic and the way we initially imagined the organism's behaviour could easily lead to a parasitic interpretation: an organism that survives by consuming something else. This was not the story we wanted to tell. Instead, we wanted the destruction to be directed inward. It would gradually consume itself, ultimately transforming into something new and more beautiful. Death therefore became less of an ending and more of a necessary stage of metamorphosis, a process of self-destruction that allows a different form of life to emerge.

This chapter covers the status of our concept before it entered the production phase. Here, we planned, designed, and drafted the concept in theory and conducted initial tests to verify the technical feasibility of our concept.

## Moodboard

selection of all the stuff we have on Miro, maybe Vassa can create something nice (if you don't have time, I can also do it ^^) /// i will add with 5 pages layout in canva later

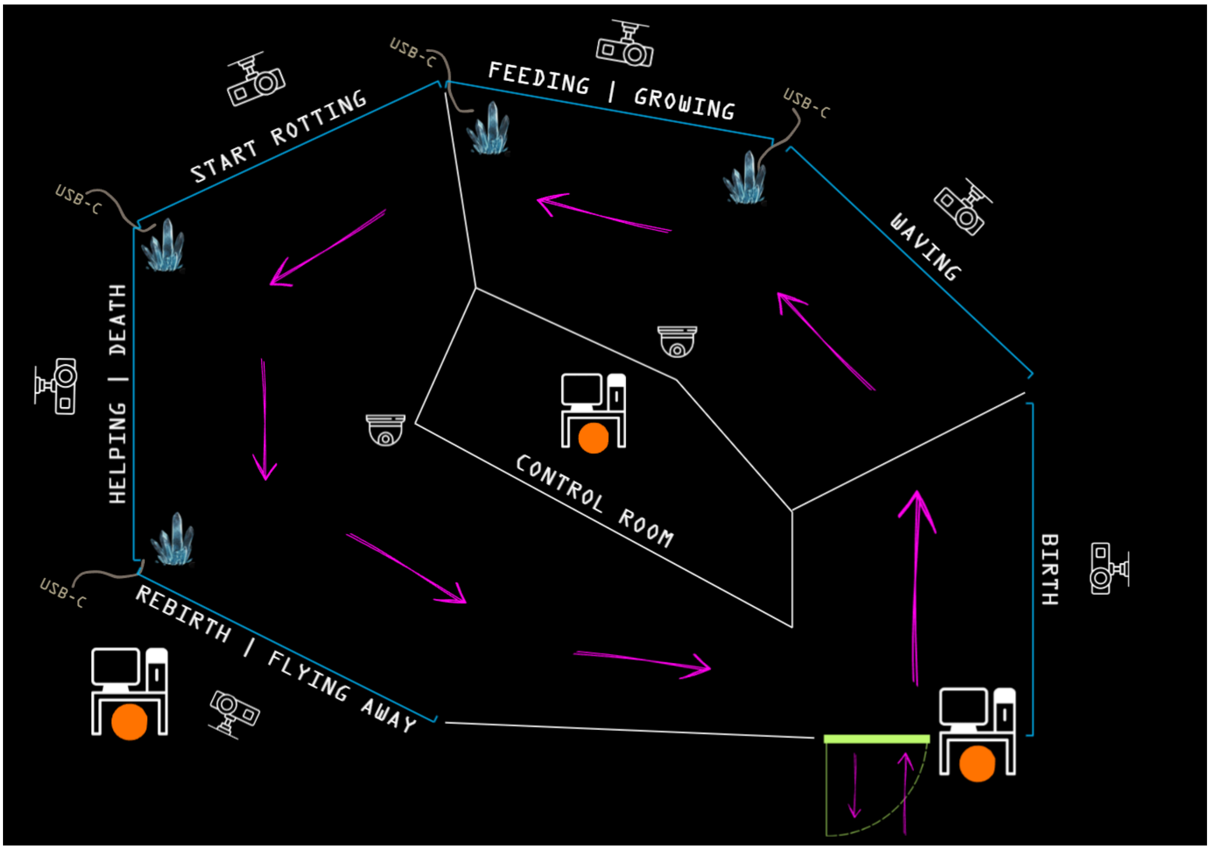
## Logistics

The labyrinth experience will take place in the “Blue Saloon” in the mensa at the Dieburg Media Campus. The room is approximately 90 square meters in size, can be almost completely darkened, has LAN connections, and offers enough space for an experience as large as the one we have planned.

“While It Lasts” is a part of the “Alive Festival,” which in turn is part of the “Werkschau.” The festival offers students, their families, professors, and other interested individuals the opportunity to celebrate the students’ projects and life itself. The festival begins at 7:00 p.m. and runs until approximately 10:30 p.m. Since we are sharing the space with another team, our project will be open from 7:00 PM to 8:30 PM. This will be followed by a half-hour setup period before the next team takes over the space.

Based on the size of the room, we have set a maximum group size of 5 visitors, who will explore our maze as a group of “explorers.” A walkthrough takes about 7 minutes. Visitors are guided through the maze once in a circular route, starting and ending at the same entrance/exit. As soon as one group has finished, the next can begin.

Our room layout has evolved over the course of production. For more details, see “Production Process > The Blue Salon.” Below is the version of our layout (including the technology and control room) that was planned during the concept phase:



# Expanded Media Design

## Story World

“While It Lasts” is set on the fictional planet Kharos-9, a world made up of one vast, interconnected cave system where all life exists. In contrast, the planet's surface is barren and abandoned. A team of researchers (played by us, the Queens) discovers the hidden cave system and begins to map it. They encounter an unknown species unlike anything seen before. Living in an environment free of natural predators, these gentle creatures float freely through the cave system, feed on energy stored within glowing crystals, live in close social groups, and navigate using ultrasonic echoes. To study the species without disturbing it, the researchers call in an exploration team (the visitors) to make first contact. But by the time they arrive, it is almost too late. A mysterious rot has spread through the cave system, wiping out the entire population. Only a single cocoon, hidden deep within the caves, has survived. The explorers are given a new mission: get in contact with and protect the last remaining creature, whose name is Ori.

In the course of the experience, participants take on two roles. As **explorers**, they enter an unknown cave system to investigate and protect the last remaining life form. As **companions**, they move beyond observation, guiding and supporting the creature through its journey, including its final moments and beyond that.

- pictures of caves? like the inspo pics we had on miro
- Harrison Ford Pictures

## Immersion

The immersion is created through a combination of visual, auditory, and sensory elements that surround the participants and bring the world of Kharos-9 to life. The experience takes place across six large screens which are sectioned by black curtains. This way we create the feeling of going deeper inside the cave system. The cave system is created in Unreal Engine, with detailed environments, including the last creature, glowing crystals, rocky formations, stalagmites and the rot. The visuals are supported by atmospheric lighting and particles. Apart from that we use a special sound behind each of the screens. The audio is a mix of electronic music, cave ambient and the sound of the creature. Additional sensory elements, such as cave-like scent or touchable crystals, further connect the virtual environment with the physical space.

## Interaction

The main interaction of the experience focuses on building a connection between the visitors and Ori, the last surviving creature of Kharos-9. The first way visitors can interact with Ori is through feeding. Ori survives by absorbing energy from the glowing crystals inside the cave. Visitors can support him by touching a physical crystal, which is connected to an ESP32 and integrated into Unreal Engine. This physical interaction triggers a real-time sequence in the virtual environment. Later in the experience, visitors can interact with the crystal again, this time in an attempt to save Ori.

A more indirect interaction focuses on communication and trust. At the beginning, Ori is afraid of the visitors and keeps its distance. After the first shock, Ori slowly begins to approach them and communicates by moving its antennae n a waving motion. Visitors can respond by mimicking this gesture.

### Participation

Participation emerges through the collective journey of the visitors inside the cave system. Visitors do not experience the story alone; they share the space with each other, observe each other's reactions, cooperate during interactions, and experience Ori's journey together. By feeding the creature, gaining its trust, and witnessing its suffering, death, and rebirth, visitors become emotionally connected to Ori.

The participation continues beyond the experience through the flower seeds that visitors can take home at the end. This small gesture creates a personal connection between the visitors and the themes of the experience, symbolically representing the cycle of life, loss, and renewal in their own lives.

## Walkthrough (5E)

### Excitement (one month before experience)

The year is 2026, and it's a mild summer evening in late June. You're sitting outside by the river with friends, an Aperol in one hand and your phone in the other. You're enjoying the last rays of sunshine and scrolling through posts on Instagram. Just a little over a month to go, and the semester break will finally be here. It would be nice to celebrate the end of the semester. Just at that moment (because the universe is sometimes strange) a post from *mediencampus.hda* pops up. It's an ad for a festival. The ALIVE Festival. Intrigued, you watch the video. It shows a creature with big eyes staring straight into the camera, flinching, and hiding behind a rock. A soft "Oww" escapes your lips. Your friends look over your shoulder, curious. The creature in the video peeks out from behind the rock once more, then disappears completely. A heartbeat can be heard amid the electronic beats. Then the words "While It Lasts" and a date at the end of July, right after your exams. "We should go there," you say to your friends. "It looks pretty cool, and apparently the event is right in our mensa." Your friends nod enthusiastically. Only one of them grimaces. "The mensa? Really? I can hardly imagine it turning into a good party spot." You smile indulgently. "Come on, it'll be fine. I've been to an event in the mensa before, and we're still on campus anyway." You go to the linked website to find out more details and convince your skeptical friend. The website has the same style as the teaser video. It looks like the entrance of an old cage. On the walls are fossil structures and glowing crystals. One question immediately catches your eye: "What makes you feel alive?" You think for a moment and type in your answer. Then you look at the answers from others who've visited the site. There are funny, beautiful, and even bizarre responses. You soak up all the information and look forward to the evening. Apparently, there are different stations; in addition to the labyrinth, there's also a Main Stage and a VR Experience. You're always fascinated by what media studies programs create and are already looking forward to the evening.

—Time jump: the evening of July 24

From outside, you can already see colorful lights and hear music. The party has been going on for half an hour, and the air is buzzing with energy. It feels a little strange as you walk up the steps to the mensa with your friends. Usually, you're only here to eat mediocre food or do group work in the study area at the back. The atmosphere is instantly different, and you feel the tension of the last few days slowly melt away. Excited and full of anticipation, you look around.

Your gaze falls on a door to your right. The words “While It Lasts” are visible. Next to the door are installations made of crepe paper. They look like crystals. The installation is bathed in blue light, and more lights dance across the walls. People stop in front of it and take photos. You take a closer look inside. At the end of a short passage, you see a cave entrance, with more of the crystals standing there. Your friends pull you toward the dance floor, where you laugh together, enjoy the music, and have a good time. After a while, however, you need a break from the bass and the volume. Together with a friend, you step away from the hustle and bustle. You decide to finally check out the experience you passed earlier.

## Entry (1min)

You're standing in the passage that leads to the labyrinth. Someone from the Labyrinth team comes over to you and says, “Hello, explorers. We're so glad you were able to make it. Our scanners have detected a life form, probably the last of its kind. We're currently testing to see if the atmosphere is stable enough to let you in. I'll be right back with an update.” The person walks back to some computers. You can see the interior of the cave, which was captured using LiDAR. The person is typing on the keyboard. You use the waiting time to look around the area with curiosity. More crepe paper installations adorn the walls, giving you the feeling that you're about to step into another world. Although you're excited, you feel the adrenaline from the Main Stage slowly fade away and you begin to calm down. There's a faint scent of mud and grass. That musty, damp smell you find in old basements and caves. You and your friend are standing there with three strangers. You wonder what kind of life form it is and why it's the last of its kind. The person from the Labyrinth Team returns and tells you that the atmosphere has stabilized and you can enter the cave safely. The cave entrance is narrow, and you go in one by one. The musty smell grows stronger. It's relatively dark in the small room. The walls are made of stone and ancient vein-like fossils. In some places, glowing crystals protrude from the surface.The floor creaks softly under your footsteps. In the background, you hear a faint pulsing sound that grows louder the further you go. Your gaze immediately falls on a large screen. It shows another part of the cave. A cocoon dangles from the ceiling. It pulses slightly in time with the pulsing sound, which you can now hear clearly. Something inside is moving. You watch transfixed as the movements grow stronger and the cocoon begins to wobble. Is that the life form? You look around searchingly. In the background, you see shreds of an empty cocoon. Apparently, its inhabitants have already hatched. Your thoughts are interrupted by a popping sound. The cocoon hangs flat, slimy threads stretching all the way to the ground. The scene slowly zooms in as a small creature floats out from behind a rock. You start to hear soft electronic music that mixes with the heartbeat of the creature.

The creature's head is almost as big as the rest of its body. As it tries to float through the cave, it does a somersault. It paddles with its little arms and manages to steady itself. Its large, round eyes look around in confusion. It hasn't noticed you yet. When it lets out a clicking sound, it echoes through the cave system. The strange antennae on the creature's head twitch. It seems to be listening to the echo caused by its sound. Suddenly, it flinches back from you. Thanks to the echo, it now knows you're there. The creature lets out another sound, this time quieter. Its antennae twitch again, listening to the vibrations. It moves away from you as fast as it can and disappears off-screen into the next room. You exchange a moment of uncertain glances. But since your mission is to explore this life form, you push the curtains aside and follow the creature deeper into the cave.

### Engagement (5-6min)

The next section of the cave is displayed on two screens. Between the screens are the same crystal formations as at the entrance. They glow faintly. The cave on the screens is also studded with crystals. They stick out of the walls and illuminate the ancient rocks. At first glance, you see no sign of the creature. You only see remnants of its species: empty cocoons, slimy shreds of skin scattered across the rough walls. Decaying bodies from which strange plants are growing. Whatever happened here wiped out an entire species. Only one creature remains. As you look around further, you see the creature's head peeking out from behind a rock. Its antennae sway gently back and forth. It lets out another sound to figure out where you are. Then, slowly, it extends its head a little further and wiggles one of its antennae. It looks like it's waving? The creature stops again. And lets out a clicking sound. It echoes around you. When you don't react, the creature repeats the movement a few seconds later. Hesitantly, you raise your arm and wave back. The creature makes another clicking sound and recognizes your movement by the echo. A joyful chirp sounds. The creature ventures out of its hiding place and waves at you once more. When you wave back, it floats excitedly around the cave, repeatedly letting out chirping sounds. It thought it was alone in this world, but now it has found you and is filled with hope once more. It flies excitedly toward the nearest screen and bumps into one of the glowing crystals. Confused, it shakes itself. Glowing particles emerge from the crystal. The creature looks at them curiously and sniffs. Then it lunges at them, opens its mouth wide, and inhales the particles. Its entire body glows, and you see the particles passing through it. The electronic music and the heartbeat pick up speed. The creature is excited. It has found something to eat. It flies closer to you and points its antennae toward the glowing crystal standing next to the screen. You and the others exchange a brief glance. "Do you think we can just touch it?" You step forward and examine the crystal more closely. There is a notch in it that is large enough for a hand. Hesitantly, you place your hand on it. The crystal glows brighter for a moment. More of the particles appear on the screen, which the creature happily devours. The crystal stops glowing. You place your hand on it again, but no more particles appear. Another person from your group steps up to a different glowing crystal and places their hand on it as well. More particles appear on the screen. The creature eats happily as you feed it.

After a while, the creature stops eating. Instead, it lets out a satisfied chirp and wiggles its antennae. It looks so cute. You can't help but smile. Suddenly, the creature begins to glow brighter and brighter. So bright that its outline blurs and the entire cave is illuminated. You squint your eyes. A draft blows through the cave and the soft heartbeat turns into a powerful thudding. As the light recedes, a surprised gasp escapes you. The cute creature in front of you has grown. Not just grown, but matured. "It has lost some of its childlike features, its body is longer, the organs inside more visible. You see its heart pulsing in time with the beat. When it makes the clicking sound now, it sounds much deeper and more eerie. It looks a little creepy, like some kind of strange, alien-like creature. But then its antennae wiggle, and it chirps at you, and you know that nothing has changed. It moves in time with the electronic music for a while before continuing to explore the cave. It floats through it, using its antennae to navigate. When you realize where it's headed, your chest tightens. It's heading straight for the other, rotting creatures. It floats around them, letting out soft cries again and again, hoping for a response. But no one reacts. The decaying remains are covered in mold. Shredded organs and pieces of skin spread across the rock, forming a slimy film. Plants are slowly growing out of the bodies, lending death a strange beauty. The creature goes deeper into the cave and disappears off-screen. You're a little afraid of what might be waiting for you behind the next curtain. Especially when you hear the creature's terrified screams. But you can't very well leave the creature alone now, so you head deeper into the cave with the others.

The first thing you notice is your racing heart and the distorted electronic music. Something isn't right. Then you see the room. You see mold and decay and plants clinging to the rocky walls. None of the creatures are recognizable as such anymore. The Rotting has already taken over everything. The last living creature floats amidst all this chaos. Its eyes are swimming in water and its antennae hang limply. Again and again, it cries out softly. But it receives no answer. With horror, you see that decay has also affected your creature. The first moldy spots are forming on its tail. The creature flinches. It has noticed it too, feels it in every skin cell. It screeches and wags its tail vigorously to shake off the rotting. It is scared; it doesn't want to end like the rest of its family. The music grows more intense, the beat faster, and its heart skips a beat again and again. There is a metallic smell in the air. The creature desperately tries to conceal the decay, to get rid of it somehow. Its movements grow weaker, its eyes glaze over, and it's being eaten away from the inside out. It looks at you desperately, helplessly. It wants more time with you; more time alive. It keeps drifting toward the crystals, but it is too weak to bump into them and eat the particles. For a moment, you are too stunned to do anything. Then you realize that you can help. Perhaps the energy will help fight the decay. The glowing crystals standing next to the screens. You quickly step over and touch them. The blue particles float around the creature. But it doesn't want to eat. It shakes its head, the antennas moving weakly. No matter how desperately you wish you could change things, the rotting has already sunk its long, sharp claws into your friend. It has a cold heart and an iron grip.

### Exit (1min)

The creature glides slowly through the cave. The first bumps form on its body and burst. Its heartbeat slows, the music softens. The creature finds a spot near you, a place free of rotting. Only stones and crystals. It chirps at you. As if to calm you, and not the other way around. There is something deeply sad about seeing this creature so weak. It curls up protectively as the rotting spreads further. One last time, it waves to you with its antenna. Then the rotting has reached its heart. In an instant, it becomes terribly quiet in the cave. No heartbeat, no music. Only the hissing of dissolving skin. Your creature, the last of its kind, turns to mold and nourishes the stone beneath it. Plants sprout from its organs, clinging to the rocks and climbing upward. Now the entire cave system is covered by the rotting creatures. You look away. Tears well up in your eyes. It's silly to cry, silly to feel anything for a creature you've known for barely five minutes. But maybe it's not just about the creature. Maybe it's about the feeling of loss, of losing something you love. The pain that lingers long after life has passed. The pain that remains in every moment. You think of your grandmother and her final hours. Of your cat. Of all life that will never be again. You and the others stand there in complete silence. There is a heaviness in the air that is hard to describe and even harder to grasp. You're not sure how many seconds pass, how many breaths go by, how much blood your heart pumps through your body.

Suddenly, the music starts playing again. The strange plants around you grow faster. Life floods the cave so intensely that you hold your breath. The rotting disappears, becoming one with the stone and forming another layer. The remains of the creatures begin to glow. Brighter and brighter, until the crystals around you glow again as well. And then a heartbeat. Strong and steady. As the light fades, you see the creatures. They float in the air, their gentle cries, their pure joy echoing off the walls. Their bodies have changed, showing traces of the rotting. But it is no longer dangerous. They have been resurrected. The last piece that was missing was your creature. The last creature. And it is this one that flies closer to you and waves at you with its antenna. You wave back and feel warmth rushing through your body. The creatures are not dead. It was just a part of their cycle. Perhaps death is merely a condition of life and not its end. Perhaps atoms form new constellations again and again. Perhaps this is not an end and only a new beginning. The creatures float toward the cave's exit, toward the light. Their chirping echoes for a while longer before they vanish and the curtain to the exit opens for you.

### Extension (forever)

This marks the end of the experience. At the exit, there's a table with a sign that reads, "Take a part of the creature with you." An arrow points to the sticker. You and your friend each take one and step outside into the fresh air to look at it in peace. Inside is a card designed like the labyrinth, a sticker of the creature in its cutest form. A part of you. A part of life itself.

## Concept Design / Style

Early in the development phase, each team member created their own mood board reflecting their vision for the project's visual style. Despite differences in references and color palettes, it became clear during discussions that most team members were intuitively moving in the same direction. Based on these, Vassa developed a common artistic concept for the project, unifying the ideas and preferences of the entire team into a single stylistic direction.

The central idea was the image of a translucent living organism. Instead of the usual fantasy creatures, we were inspired by forms reminiscent of jellyfish, deep-sea animals, microorganisms, fungi, and embryonic structures. Such objects appear at once alive, fragile, and mysterious, creating a sense of an unfamiliar yet real biology.

Another common feature of virtually all the mood boards was the interaction of light with the organism's surface. Many references featured transparent or translucent materials through which light passes, creating soft gradients, internal glow, and refraction. As a result, the objects are perceived not as solid bodies but as living tissues filled with fluid.

Branching vascular structures like veins, capillaries, root systems, and organic branches. They were also present in virtually all the compositions. In some images, they were visible beneath the skin’s surface; in others, they became part of the external anatomy.

As a result, both the environment and the character share the same visual style, based on organic shapes, translucent materials, internal vein-like structures, and realistic light interaction. This creates the feeling that all elements belong to the same living ecosystem and gives the project a cohesive visual identity.

## Planned Implementation

**Technology**
For the technology, we decided to use software and tools we were already familiar with. Vassa and Isa have experience with Unreal Engine and a background in game development, which made the decision to use Unreal and incorporate game-like features into the experience a natural one. Rafael’s experience as a VFX artist with Autodesk Maya and SideFX Houdini also supported the visual and interactive aspects of the project, while Kim’s experience with microcontrollers helped us develop the physical interaction with the crystal.

The planned implementation was as follows: We’ll be using Unreal Engine for the cave environment. Since the software is designed for game development and there are plenty of free assets available, we can use it to create an immersive and realistic environment relatively easily. For Ori’s 3D models and animations, we’ll primarily use Autodesk Maya, and for materials and visual effects on the model, we’ll use SideFX Houdini. The models, animations, and materials can be imported into Unreal Engine and then set up in scenes using the Sequencer. We have a total of six scenes spread across six screens. At the very beginning of our process, we considered making three of these scenes fully interactive. However, as we progressed, we decided to focus on just one scene. It was more important to us to make one interaction really good rather than three that were very poor.

The fully interactive scene is the feeding scene. There, visitors will have the opportunity to feed Ori using a physical crystal. To do this, we plan to use the TouchPin of an ESP32 in combination with copper foil (which conducts electricity well) and an LED strip for visual feedback. The technology will be hidden inside a crystal made of foam and covered with copper foil. The ESP32 will send a signal via serial communication to Unreal Engine, triggering a particle system and an animation there.

**Website**
Besides the installation itself, we planned a website as the first touchpoint of the experience. It was meant to carry the same visual language and let visitors take part in the story before the festival. We have one question: “ What makes you feel alive?”, that anyone could answer and we can collect on a cave wall on our site. The idea was to let the experience begin before the event started and make visitors interact and excited.

**Souvenirs**
For the extension stage, we had planned to give visitors flower seeds in an envelope and stickers. The flower seeds were meant to symbolize the life that visitors could bring to their

own homes. However, due to cost considerations, we dropped the seeds, but kept the printed part as a souvenir.

**Set Design**
We had a lot of ideas for the set design and the overall cave atmosphere, as long as we had enough time. The ideas included a cave scent, research costumes for our team, decorative elements for the area in front of our room, and crystals inside the cave itself. Not all of these were implemented. More on this in the next chapter.

# Production Process

To ensure that our concept was realistic, we conducted various tests at different points throughout the production process. Based on the results, we were able to adjust and refine certain aspects and optimize our workflow.
We tested a wide range of different elements of the experience. This included testing materials, the animations of Ori's 3D model, the shape and construction of the crystal, and even the scent we planned to use inside the cave. On the technical side, we tested different screen resolutions, render settings, and workflows in Unreal Engine to find the most efficient way of working with our setup. We also tested whether the videos and audio could be triggered correctly through TouchDesigner.

Besides the individual components, we tested the experience as a whole. We experimented with the visitor flow inside the room to make sure people could move through the experience naturally and understand what they were supposed to do. These tests helped us identify problems early and make changes before the festival.

## Creature Design in Autodesk Maya and SideFX Houdini

After developing the story concept and identifying the core emotions we needed out of the performance of our alien creature, we dived into developing the look and feel of Ori. We experimented with a wide variety of looks, from cute and overly animated versions to conceptual beings out of the darkest of abysses.

At first we leaned on keeping things abstract as we felt it added to the mystery of the overall ambiance but after getting feedback we had to make a few adjustments. The fact was that we had to make people empathize with Ori from the start and while an abstract alien sounds amazing, we had to think about instant likeability. We pivoted and revisited the cute concepts, taking features like huge eyes and oversized heads. After mixing all these elements we successfully finalized our new version of Ori. Testament to its cuteness came after our midterm presentation after revealing baby Ori to our peers, we even heard some say “aww”.

At first it was planned to use Houdini as the main modelling, animation, and FX software as it is a versatile workhorse but as we delved deeper into production it was clear we needed to scrap it. Maya became the main software for this part of the pipeline as it is known to handle exporting to Unreal Engine well and all texture maps were procedurally generated in Mari. This gave us the ease of iterating quickly in case we wanted to see more material variations.

As a team we determined the three different stages of Ori which were egg, baby, and adult, their modelling and rigging time-frame and all the different emotions that needed to be loop-animated. As complexity increased, also estimated time, and adult Ori was the most complex out of all them.

Rafael began with the egg, it was by far the most simple and it only needed to do one thing; swing. Focusing on big movements and then secondary adjustments sold the fleshyness of the egg sack and was quite successful on screen. Then came baby Ori and this model, at first, featured inner eyeballs that were fully animatable but here we had our first roadblock. Unreal Engine does not like to have layers of translucent and opaque properties stacked into one single material. A work around was found by using native UE parallax materials and texture maps to fake depth inside the eye area. After this problem was solved it was time to begin animating baby Ori and in total we had 12 distinct emotions for Kim, Isa, and Vassa to use inside UE.

Not everything went smoothly, at one point Isa and Rafael had to troubleshoot for a couple of hours to update Ori's UV map (texture coordinates to map materials to geometry) in order to get rid of an artifact. Meanwhile adult Ori needed to be done so again there was modelling, rigging, texturing and animating for it and in total we came up with 9 complex emotions. Adult Ori's animations were longer and had complex motion in order to convey pain and death.

After 3 models, 3 rigs, 4 sets of textures, and 23 different animations we were able to put together a compelling set of scenes inside Unreal Engine.

## Cave Creation in Unreal Engine

The project environment was designed and built by Vassa in Unreal Engine 5. After defining the project's overall artistic concept, the main challenge was to create a space that would feel like a living organism rather than an ordinary cave. We wanted to achieve the atmosphere of a closed-off, dark, and cramped world that simultaneously evokes a sense of depth and the unknown. Despite the limited space, each location was designed to feel three-dimensional through the use of lighting, composition, and the layered nature of the environment.

When creating the environment, our inspiration was from organic structures similar to the internal architecture of termite mounds, wasp nests, and natural biological formations. Instead of the usual stone walls, the cave is a living system consisting of intertwining organic tissues, vessels, cavities, and root-like structures.

The Cave Asset Pack was used as the foundation for building the scenes. All game locations were completely assembled and reworked by hand in Unreal Engine. 6 unique scenes were created based on existing assets. All organic elements (their placement, composition, and lighting) were designed specifically for the project's storyline.

As the story unfolds, the environment gradually changes along with the emotional tone of the narrative. The first locations appear relatively calm and allow the viewer to become acquainted with this new world. However, with each subsequent screen, the space becomes increasingly gloomy and unsettling. Massive vascular formations, sprawling veins, rotting organic matter, and deformed root structures appear on the walls. Gradually, the impression is created that the cave itself is infected and slowly decaying. Starting with the 4 location, the viewer sees the consequences of the unfolding events for the first time. The remains of the protagonist's fallen kin appear in the surroundings, and the number of organic growths increases significantly. These details gradually prepare the viewer for the tragic finale.

Special attention was paid to the artistic staging of the scenes. Lighting, volumetric fog, reflections, post-processing, and the particle system were customized separately for each location.

////i will add photo before and after

## Crystal Technology

We combined hardware with Unreal Engine to create an interactive experience. The goal was to connect a physical crystal to the digital world so that every touch would trigger audiovisual feedback.

**Hardware**
Kim did the first implementation using an ESP32 WROVER-B microcontroller. The ESP32's touch pin detects changes in electrical capacitance when a person touches a conductive material connected to it. In our project, this allowed us to turn the physical crystal into a touch-sensitive object using copper tape along its edges. This meant visitors could touch the crystal almost anywhere instead of having to find one specific spot. Each detected touch increased a counter and gradually changed the brightness of a blue LED, providing visual feedback. The ESP32 also sent the touch information via serial communication to Unreal Engine, where it triggered the corresponding animation and particle effects.

**Unreal Engine**
The logic of the experience was created in Unreal Engine by Isa (and Olli, our secret 6th team member). To communicate with the ESP32, we used the SerialCOM plugin. This made the serial connection much easier to set up. However, the plugin only supported older versions of Unreal Engine, so we had to use an older version for this project which ultimately had no major setbacks but still came with some disadvantages regarding other plugins and the newer effects of the Niagara system.

When Unreal received a touch signal, several things happened at the same time. The particle effects appeared, sound effects were played, and Ori's absorb animation was triggered.

The particle effects were created with Niagara. They represented the crystal's energy flowing towards Ori and helped make the interaction feel more realistic.

**Interaction Flow**
When the application started, a static image of the cave was displayed. Since the projection was visible from the beginning when entering the experience, this made it look like the cave was always present.

Pressing the **P** key started the introduction cutscene. During this time, the crystal was reset and all touch inputs were ignored. This prevented visitors from interacting before the experience had officially started.

Once the cutscene finished, the interactive part began. Every touch on the crystal triggered the particle effects, sounds, Ori's absorb animation, and reduced the brightness of the LED strip.

After the final touch, the ending cutscene was played automatically. Once it finished, the application returned to the cave image and reset itself. To start the experience again, it was only necessary to press **P** without restarting the game.

**Fail-safes**
Since the installation was shown at a public exhibition, we expected that some visitors, especially children, might touch the crystal very quickly or aggressively. To prevent problems, we added a short delay between registered touches. This made it impossible to trigger all touches at once.

We also included a manual backup. If the connection between the copper and touchpin or ESP32 and Unreal stopped working, pressing the **1** key on the keyboard manually triggered the particle system. This allowed us to continue the experience without having to stop and fix the hardware first.

## Crystal Design

Stage 1: The idea came from the story. For the crystal design we started in May. We conclude that it will be touched anywhere and glowing and look blend to the cave.

Stage 2: Material test and Structure. 6th June starting testing the copper test and ordering EVA foam. 13th decide to move copper tape outside crystals and place touchpin at the bottom with LED.

Stage 3: Decrease Crystal from 2-3 intractable to 1 pieces. Due to Unreal only reads one input and cannot connect two ESP32. So, it concludes to make one crystal and spare the backup in case of damage and the rest is decorative. and The limit of technology's turnout benefit to make less work for crystals.

Stage 4: Testing Structure (2 prototypes) (14th July). As a result, it shows that if you put the medal wire at the corner of the crystal it will make a smooth surface but not stable. but if you put the medal wire at the center of the panel before putting it together it will be the most stable and form. and the incline version gives the least stability but could be decorative and adapt to the incline crystal from the base. Isa notices that there would be a “stupid and drunk" audience who might damage the crystal so decide which is the most stable is the best. 17th July, Rafael model crystal relates to the real crystals model with coppery edges.

Final stage: Production, 21th July Thai reaching 24 pieces and spending all the materials and putting copper tape. We plan to use 3 chunks of crystal in the event and two of them could be interactable and the intractable part has 5 pieces per chunk while 1 decorative chunk has only 3 pieces. So Thai made 13 for display and another 13 pieces for spare but with technical problems, we decided to reduce it to having only 1 interactable chunk to display. At the end we have 1 chunk (5 pieces of crystal) for interactive and the rest is spare for accident and replacement (19 pieces) at the event. and we found that some kid had pulled the crystal out from the base and proved that fail-safe is very essential.

## Website & Cave Wall

The site was developed by Thai using Claude coding, starting from an existing template rather than scratch. Features were then added step by step. One of the first was the heartbeat, the same pulse used in the teaser and installation, so that visitors would recognise the sound again later inside the labyrinth.

The Central interactive element was the Cave Wall. Visitors could type their answer to the question "What makes you feel alive?" directly into the site and then read what others had written. Storing those answers turned out to be the first real problem. Initial setup would have required running a local server, which in practice meant keeping a private computer online permanently for the entire run-up to the festival. Kim suggested using Google Firebase instead. Moving the storage there solved it. The answers are kept in a hosted database and stay online. The first version still needed some debugging, but once it was running it proved stable. Thai built a small admin backend due to the Firebase plan comes with a usage limit. Submitted answers are not published immediately, but have to be approved before they appear on the Cave Wall. This gave us control over both the content and the amount of data stored

The site was updated several times in the weeks before the festival. The teaser video was added once it was finished, and schedule was corrected when the festival timings changed.
**Link:** While It lasts: Website

## Souvenir

It was ordered from a print shop, which meant a lead time of about two weeks including die-cutting. It had to be finalized well before the rest of the production was finished. We ordered 55 sets in total. Each set consists of a round sticker, used as a seal for the envelope, and a sticker sheet with Ori and objects from the cave. So we have a total of 110 pieces from the round sticker and main sticker. We handed out the main sticker first and, once those were gone, continued with the round seals until the stock ran out. With over 150 visitors, 110 pieces were not enough.

## Sound Design

While working on the sound design for the project, Artem (Data Drain), our sound designer, drew inspiration from the alien fauna of Scavengers Reign as well as the broader depiction of extraterrestrial creatures in science fiction.

To create the sound design for the main character, he developed a custom tool that allowed him to quickly control the creature's emotional state by adjusting the degree of randomization applied to the pitch and warp parameters of carefully selected and synthesized sounds representing its different reactions. This approach made it possible to produce expressive and varied vocalizations while maintaining a consistent sonic identity.

In addition to designing the creature's vocal sounds, Artem manually recorded and processed the sounds of its movement through the environment. He also composed the original soundtrack, with each musical theme reflecting a different stage of the creature's life cycle.

The primary instrument used throughout the soundtrack was a modified piano. The compositions begin in C major, symbolizing innocence and the beginning of the creature's journey. As the story progresses and the protagonist gradually decays, the music evolves into darker, minor harmonies with increasingly unsettling textures. In the final scene, the score returns to the pure, original piano motif in C major, bringing the narrative full circle and reinforcing the emotional conclusion of the story.

## The Blue Salon

The Blue Salon was the space we used to bring “While It Lasts” to life. Our goal was to transform the room into an immersive cave environment while still working with the existing space and its limitations.

We used the six screens to create the main visual environment and arranged them around the room so that visitors were going deeper inside the cave in a circle. Black curtains were used to cover parts of the room (like the control rooms) and block unwanted outside light. We also used lighting to support the atmosphere and make the transition into the experience feel more immersive. In addition to the visual elements, we introduced a scent to further strengthen the feeling of being inside a cave.

The setup changed throughout the production process as we tested how visitors moved through the room and how the different elements worked together. One important decision was to focus the physical interaction on a single crystal rather than having multiple interactive crystals. This allowed us to put more attention into making that one interaction reliable.

## Visitor Flow & Queue

One day before the festival, Georg suggested that there could be more visitors than our setup could handle and end up standing in the corridor. We could lose the ones who got tired of waiting and walked away. Thai built a small web-based queue system with Claude coding and put it online the same day.

**How it works**
The system has two sides. On our side, the team can register an arriving group and call the next number once a group has finished every round. To move the queue faster we raised the group size from the planned five to up to ten people per round. On the visitor's side, anyone can open the page on their own phone and see which number is currently being called and where they stand in the line. All data is stored in Firebase so it always shows the same state.

**Result**
We had expected around 50 visitors over the evening. In total we counted around 150 visitors through the queue system. with repeat visitors and people who joined without taking a number, over 150 people went through the experience. Without it we could only have guessed.

**Link:** Admin
**Link:** Guest

## The Control Rooms

We used two control rooms to manage the technical setup of the experience. The first control room was responsible for the first two screens and the real-time Unreal Engine scene, while the second control room managed the last three screens. Both setups were controlled through TouchDesigner.

We kept the TouchDesigner files as simple as possible to minimize the risk of crashes or technical failures during the festival. Using a Movie File In TOP, we loaded the video for each screen and output it through a window to the corresponding projector. The audio was handled separately using an Audio Movie File In, which sent the sound to an audio interface. Each screen had its own speaker, allowing us to create a more immersive sound environment and make the audio feel connected to the individual screens.

With a single button, all videos could be started from the beginning at the same time. To keep the timing synchronized, all videos had the same overall length, with still frames being used whenever a screen was not showing an active scene. Using the same button together with a switch, we could also change from the movie file to a still image showing the current scene. This was useful when we needed to pause the experience or when a scene was not currently active.

The audio setup turned out to be one of the more challenging parts of the technical production, as TouchDesigner and our audio interface did not always work smoothly together. We would especially like to thank Matthias for helping us troubleshoot and get the final setup working reliably.

### Promotion - poster and stickers

- links to website and teaser
- pictures of us with poster and poster without us
- picture of stickers

# Final Experience

For us, success comes in two forms: a good grade, of course, but also how the entire “While It Lasts” experience was perceived. In the end, we would say it was a big success. The project worked, we made a person cry, and we heard a lot of “awws” and “oh no’s” from our visitors. But most importantly, even though it was stressful, we had fun. Having over 150 visitors, some of whom went through the experience twice, was also a great way to see that what we lost a lot of sleep over was a success.

The reactions of the audience were especially rewarding because they were very close to what we had hoped for. People were curious when Ori first appeared, shook their heads when he did, felt sad when he died, and were relieved when he came back. Seeing these emotional reactions showed us that the story was understandable and that people actually connected with Ori.

Of course, not everything worked perfectly from the beginning. One thing we noticed was that visitors were sometimes unsure when the experience had ended. Even though we had a fade to black at the end, some people still did not know when to leave. We solved this by having Rafael guide visitors outside once their experience was finished. We also noticed that some visitors were unsure how often they could touch the crystal, or that they could touch it at all. We improved the introduction to make this interaction clearer. A funny example was when some people from Isa’s and Kim’s old UI/UX study program touched the crystals shown on the screens because they assumed that all of the crystals were interactive (Haha idiots).

We clearly split the responsibilities during the festival. Kim and Isa stayed in the control room, making sure that the technical side of the experience was running smoothly, while Rafael, Vassa, and Thai stayed outside to welcome visitors and guide them. This allowed us to react quickly when something went wrong while still giving visitors a smooth experience.

All in all, we’re very happy with how things went and are thrilled that so many people stopped by to experience “While It Lasts.” Seeing the reactions of our visitors and watching them connect with Ori made all the hard work worthwhile.

### Snippets from the Festival

(just pictures with maybe small text like: here you see Kim sleeping whatever)

# Learnings

## Group Learnings

A project of this scope is no easy task, even when having such a great team like we do. We found out that by broadening our plans and later focusing on the smaller details, the good-to-have things, we were able to tackle this beast. This approach enabled us to iterate and gather feedback quickly to adjust the overall trajectory. Scheduling was also a huge part of the success of our project as we had many little pieces that needed to be dealt with before moving on to the next step. Together we figured what could be worked parallelly, like getting all the interactive parts, environments, and animations started. This allowed us to get most technicalities out of the way in order to focus on bringing all elements together.

We also learned a few things along the way. One of them being that, apparently, we all hate Unreal Engine. Working with it (and other programs) showed us how important it is to test early, especially when it comes to understanding the limitations of the technology we are working with. Testing early allowed us to make better decisions and adapt our plans before we had already invested too much time into something that might not work as intended.

No matter the project, communication is always key. Working with friends has its benefits and sometimes its hindrances and we came across the latter quite quickly. We drop the ball on things like scheduled commitments or delivery of tasks and we assume that it's okay or we don’t really give it a second thought but we have to be responsible for our faults as well as our success. After one incident, part of the team committed to doing better and this was a wake up call to really commit and work for the betterment of the group work.

Finally, we’d like to take this opportunity to express our sincere thanks to King Matthias. Without his support, energy, and positive attitude, the setup days would have been much more stressful and frustrating (and we might not have had any audio). Long live the king!

## Individual Learnings

**Thai**
My work was spread across four tracks: the crystals, the website, the queue system, and souvenirs, plus the promotion I worked on with the cohesion team. None of them were the centre of the experience, but all of them had to work on the evening.

The crystals were the part I spent the most time on. Because they are the only object visitors physically touch. The final setup used five of the 24 I made. But the spares mattered; someone pulled a crystal off its base during the evening, and a replacement kept the experience running. Next time I would agree that number together with the technical setup rather than after it.
The queue system was the opposite: one evening of work before the festival, that carried the whole evening.

Outside the labyrinth, I also worked with the cohesion team on the poster and the promotion for the Alive Festival as a whole. That part turned out really well; we got a lot of compliments on how the posters looked, and the stickers ended up doing promotional work of their own. On festival day, I promoted the event in person with the fairy team across three other events, and the stickers ended up doing promotional work of their own, and people came back for more and passed them on to their friends.

Finally, thank you to Vassa and Rafael, whose art direction is the reason it looks the way it does and who delivered it perfectly. Most of the compliments we heard from visitors were about exactly the things they made. And thank you, Isa, for managing the group chat, and Kim, for supporting me. I'm glad I got to build my parts around all of your work.

**Rafa**

I came into this project knowing we would come up with something amazing. Individually we carry an immense amount of talent and knowledge, together we were able to create an immersive world that showcased imagination and discipline. At first I did not give a second thought to the possibility of us having communication issues but this quickly came to light once we reached our first hurdle.

The VFX and videogames industries have very specific technical languages and it came as a surprise that “rendered” does not mean the same thing in either. In my experience, rendered means that a 3D asset goes through modelling, texturing, animation, lighting, and then rendered through an engine. This takes time and my calculations were based on this fact. It was not until one meeting far into the project that we started discussing which scenes were to be pre-rendered and which would be interactive/live. In my mind pre-rendered meant that 5 out of 6 scenes would need to be rendered through an engine which meant that we would need at least 3 weeks to do so. Isa noticed my panic and we had a talk to clarify the process and assured me nothing would need to be traditionally rendered, that all of the animation sequences were going to be constructed inside UE and then rendered through its viewport. After this clarification I was relieved and was able to continue without worrying too much about rendering.

All this to say I learned to trust my team and their expertise, build my own pipeline to get from concept to finalized product, and how to use Unreal Engine for these types of projects. And as always I make sure to listen to the team’s feedback, we made a commitment to each other to be honest and open to receive criticism.

**Vassa**

Throughout the project, I tried to contribute to every stage of development by supporting the team with ideas, providing feedback, and helping to solve both creative and technical challenges. But my primary tasks were art concept and visual design. I was responsible for developing the project's overall artistic direction, combining the ideas of our team into a cohesive visual style.

In addition to the concept work, I created most of the project's visual presentation materials, including the poster, presentation slides, promotional 2D artwork, and other graphic assets. Inside Unreal Engine, I focused on building the atmosphere of the environments through lighting, composition, fog, particle effects, and overall visual storytelling.

Based on Rafael's animation loops, I also produced complete animatics for Scenes 4, 5, and 6.

Another important part was communication with our sound designer. Throughout development, I regularly discussed each scene with @data drain, prepared technical briefs describing the intended atmosphere and emotional tone, and continuously provided feedback during the iteration process.

This project holds kinda special place in my heart because this aesthetic is incredibly close to my own vibe. I've always loved organic forms and translucent materials, so working on this world felt very natural to me. I tried to make everything look as beautiful as possible in the short amount of time we had... and I think it turned out pretty well, haha.

I especially want to say that I really enjoyed working with this team. What I appreciated the most was that everyone learned quickly and never let a lack of experience slow them down. For example, Kim created the animatics for Scenes 1 and 2 without having any previous experience with Unreal Engine.

Queens were responsible and always completed their work on time. It was also really enjoyable to work with Rafaela's loop animations. It was an inspiration to play with his loops. And personally, it was also my first time creating animatics as well. I had previously worked with gameplay mechanics, but never with cutscenes, so it was a fun and interesting experience for me.

I think we all did a great job. >.<

**Isa**
From one labyrinth to another. From a magical fantasy world filled with ancient mysteries and forgotten kingdoms to a dark, rotting alien cave where a small creature depended on us for survival. A very natural progression, obviously.

My role in this project was a mixture of project management support, Unreal development, and occasional technical support hotline. I helped Kim with organizing the project and, because of my background in game development, supported the Unreal setup and the development of the interactive elements.

After Kim eventually gave up her shared custody of Ori after he dramatically emerged from his cocoon and waved goodbye, the responsibility of keeping him alive was passed on to me. My task was creating the logic behind the feeding interaction. Together with Kim’s knowledge of microcontrollers, we managed to prepare the food and make the crystal interactive. A surprising amount of work went into making a small alien creature eat glowing food from a rock, but apparently that is what immersive experiences require.

Besides the interaction logic, I also worked on the particle systems that helped bring the world to life. Seeing the cave slowly become more alive through particles was one of the most rewarding parts of the project. It also reminded me that visual effects are a combination of creativity, technical knowledge, and staring at numbers while wondering why the particles suddenly decided to become pink.

Helping Kim learn Unreal was another very fun opportunity. It taught me that knowing a tool yourself and explaining it to someone else are two completely different skills. Something that feels obvious after spending hours inside an engine can suddenly become a complicated puzzle when you have to explain where a hidden setting is or why Unreal decided that this specific workflow is the correct one.

Technically, I learned that real-time development can mean very different things depending on the engine background you come from. Coming from game development, I had certain expectations about workflows, performance, and limitations. Working closer with VFX showed me a different perspective on real-time production. Sorry for the panic, Rafael.

One thing remained clear throughout the project: Unreal can be a b…. sometimes. Some features felt incredibly powerful, while others seemed designed to test my patience. I learned about new limitations, such as only being able to receive one input signal from a microcontroller, and how small hardware restrictions can have a surprisingly large impact on the final experience.

Testing animations and textures with Rafael was another memorable part of the process. It was exciting to see the world come together, but it also showed how much iteration is hidden behind small details. Something that works perfectly in theory can suddenly behave completely differently once it enters the actual environment.

Beyond the technical side, this project taught me more about teamwork and communication. I usually see feedback as something directed at the work, not the person creating it. However, I learned that this perspective is not universal. At some point, giving honest feedback started to feel like a high-risk activity, and I noticed myself holding back ideas to avoid unnecessary conflict. This showed me how important trust and communication styles are within creative teams.

Eventually, after completing the feeding logic, I also gave up custody of Ori and handed him over to Vassa for his final moments and his transformation into the rot. After spending so much time making sure this little creature could survive, watching someone else take care of his inevitable fate was surprisingly emotional for something that was technically just meshes, textures, particles, and Unreal logic.

Overall, this project reminded me that interactive experiences are built from many small pieces coming together. Sometimes it means creating complex logic, sometimes it means explaining Unreal for the tenth time, and sometimes it means negotiating with an engine that refuses to cooperate. But seeing everything work together made the debugging, frustration, and questionable life choices worth it.

**Kim**
**My Role - Ori’s Aunt**

I shared custody of the project organization with Isa; meaning we were both responsible for making sure things didn't completely fall apart. I mainly took care of keeping track of deadlines, tasks, requirements and filling out the group report. During meetings, I was often the person people asked about what we had to do next, what exactly the assignment was, or when something was due. So, naturally, I had to keep a clear overview of pretty much everything at all times.

Besides the organizational side of things, I wrote the walkthrough based on our collaborative work. Since this semester went beyond concept development, I was also involved in the technical implementation of the crystal, gave birth to Ori and waved him goodbye (aka I did two scenes in Unreal Engine). I also worked on the TouchDesigner setup for the control rooms. During the festival itself, I was stationed in one of the control rooms and was responsible for the final three screens. I also did some research into scents and selected a suitable cave-like scent to complement the experience. On top of that, I wrote 72% of this documentation (+helped with the layout) and edited the video documentation together with Isa. And, obviously, I provided feedback and support during all stages of the project for my fellow queens.

That's about it :)

**Reflection & Learnings**

One of the things I enjoyed most about this semester was getting to work with people I really like. It made many aspects of both communication and collaboration much easier. We would never have gotten as far as we did without combining everyone's strengths, our terrible sense of humor, and a healthy amount of creative chaos.

At the same time, I learned that communication with friends can sometimes be challenging in its own way. Because you already know and trust each other, it can be tempting to avoid uncomfortable conversations or assume that things will work themselves out. I tend to put things that stress me on the back and hope they will resolve themselves. This has already gotten better compared to last semester, but it is something I want to continue working on by addressing issues earlier and being more open when something is bothering me.

I also learned to trust my team's decisions more fully. This can sometimes be difficult for me because of my anxiety, but during this project I learned that I don't always need to be in control of every decision and that I can trust my team to make good choices <3

One of my more unexpected learnings was that sometimes, you just have to ignore feedback. Normally, I really appreciate feedback from lecturers and am happy to implement it, but asking us one day before the festival if we could quickly add another interactive Unreal scene… no, Georg. Just no.

Speaking of an Unreal scene: I learned Unreal Engine! At least the Sequencer. I was a bit intimidated by it at first, but I'm really glad I pushed myself to use it. It meant learning a completely new tool and showed me that I'm more capable of figuring things out than I sometimes assume. A huge thanks to Vassa and Isa for answering my questions regarding it!